



JEANNE FAVRET-SAADA (b. 1934)

Unwitching the witch

A French anthropologist, Favret-Saada took fieldwork to a new level while researching her scholarly book *Deadly Words* (1977). Tackling the subject of witchcraft in the Mayenne, northwest France, the book is an exploration of anthropological methods. For Favret-Saada, beliefs about bewitchment and “unwitching” (counteracting bewitchment’s effects) could only be fully understood by insiders, so she became involved in witchcraft herself in order to interpret and write about her experiences.

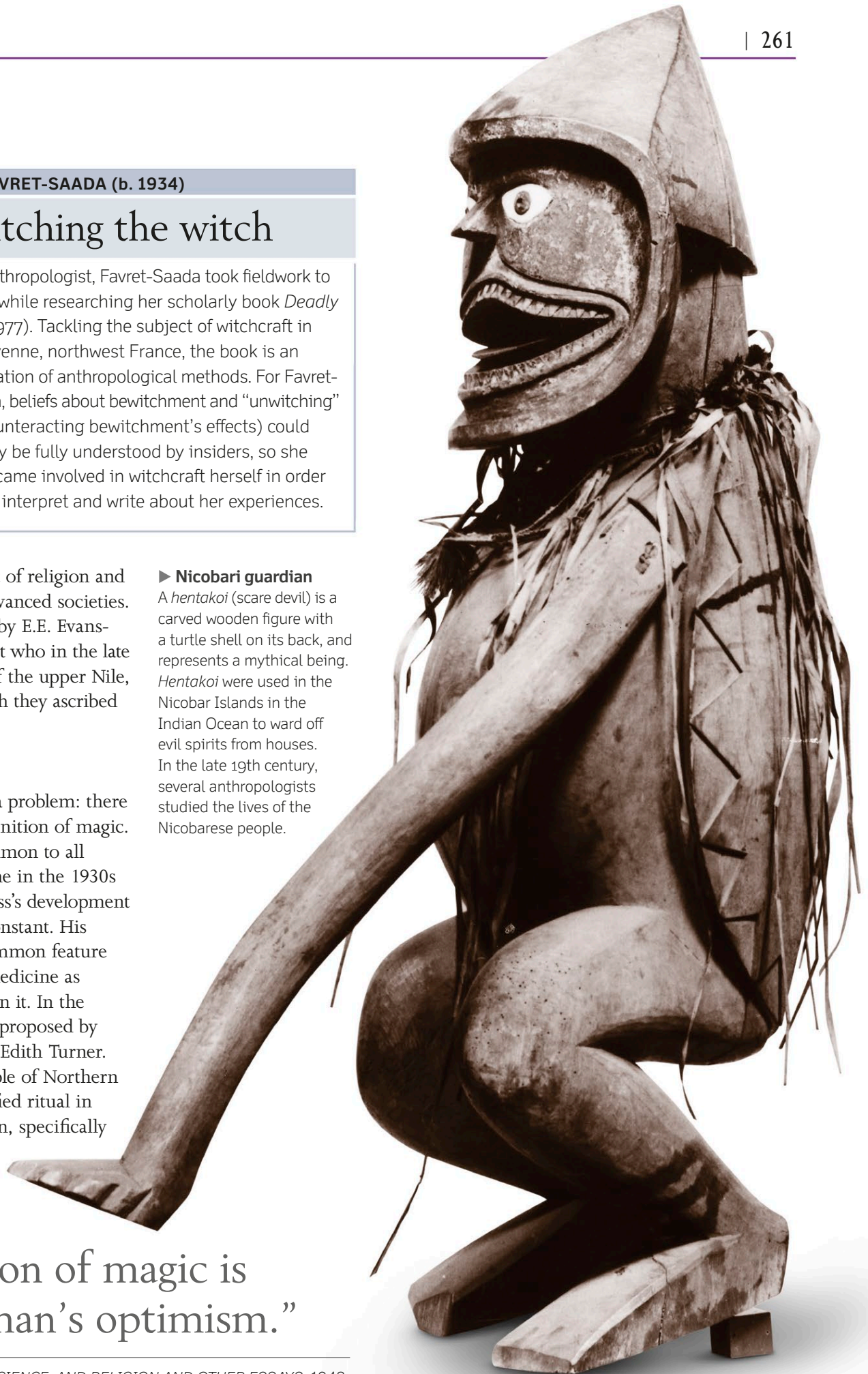
between the role of magic and that of religion and science in more technologically advanced societies. Malinowski’s work was continued by E.E. Evans-Pritchard, an English anthropologist who in the late 1920s studied the Azande people of the upper Nile, with a focus on witchcraft, to which they ascribed all misfortune.

Magic and structuralism

Early anthropological work raised a problem: there was no agreed anthropological definition of magic. Did it have universal elements common to all societies? One possible answer came in the 1930s with Frenchman Claude Lévi-Strauss’s development of the idea of magic as a human constant. His approach was that the essential common feature of magic—applicable to modern medicine as much as to shamanism—is belief in it. In the 1950s, a further characteristic was proposed by English anthropologists Victor and Edith Turner. Their work with the Ndembu people of Northern Rhodesia (modern Zambia) identified ritual in magic as a means of social cohesion, specifically in resolving disputes peacefully.

► Nicobari guardian

A *hentakoi* (scare devil) is a carved wooden figure with a turtle shell on its back, and represents a mythical being. *Hentakoi* were used in the Nicobar Islands in the Indian Ocean to ward off evil spirits from houses. In the late 19th century, several anthropologists studied the lives of the Nicobarese people.



“The function of magic is to ritualize man’s optimism.”

BRONISLAW MALINOWSKI, *MAGIC, SCIENCE, AND RELIGION AND OTHER ESSAYS*, 1948